

Comply: API Submission (Germany)

Internal TBI Guide



Version Control

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1. Introduction

1.1. Purpose of this section

The purpose of this document is to provide guidance and instruction on how Comply users submit Returns for Germany using an API. It will cover the steps required for Configuring Comply and for both Successful and Failed Submission flows.

1.2. Overview

To exchange data with the German Tax authority (via Eric), you need one or more certificates which are password protected and as such it is important to have the required PIN/Password. For the API submission, the correct combination of PFX Certificate & PIN/Password must be added in the backend of Comply.

This step is currently configured by opening a JIRA ticket with the support desk to have this added.

1.2.1. Return Types

All Return Types can be submitted via API.

- VAT Returns
- VIES
- Annual Returns
- VAT Advanced Payments

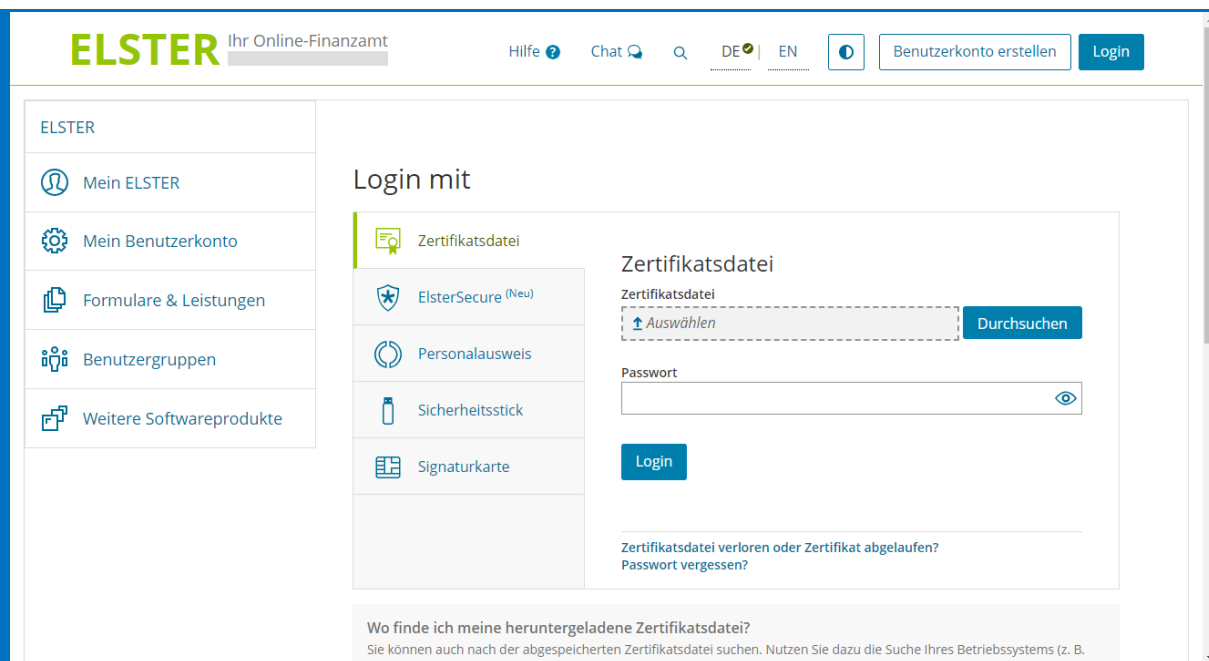
2. Tax Office Authorisation (External Steps)

In order to submit your filings digitally (Via API), the client must complete the following:

1. Register on Mein Elster <https://www.elster.de/eportal/login/softpse>
2. Request a PFX Certificate and PIN.

This certificate is the secure authorisation which allows comply to communicate digitally with the German Tax Authority on the clients behalf when submitting returns.

3. Send the PFX Certificate and PIN to TBI **via Encrypted Email**.



The screenshot shows the ELSTER login interface. At the top, the ELSTER logo is followed by the text 'Ihr Online-Finanzamt'. Navigation links include 'Hilfe', 'Chat', a search icon, and language options 'DE' and 'EN'. There are buttons for 'Benutzerkonto erstellen' and 'Login'. A left sidebar contains links to 'Mein ELSTER', 'Mein Benutzerkonto', 'Formulare & Leistungen', 'Benutzergruppen', and 'Weitere Softwareprodukte'. The main content area is titled 'Login mit' and features a list of login methods: 'Zertifikatsdatei' (selected), 'ElsterSecure (Neu)', 'Personalausweis', 'Sicherheitsstick', and 'Signaturkarte'. The 'Zertifikatsdatei' section includes a file selection button 'Auswählen', a 'Durchsuchen' button, a password field with a toggle icon, and a 'Login' button. Below this, there is a link for 'Zertifikatsdatei verloren oder Zertifikat abgelaufen? Passwort vergessen?'. At the bottom, a section titled 'Wo finde ich meine heruntergeladene Zertifikatsdatei?' provides instructions on how to find the file.

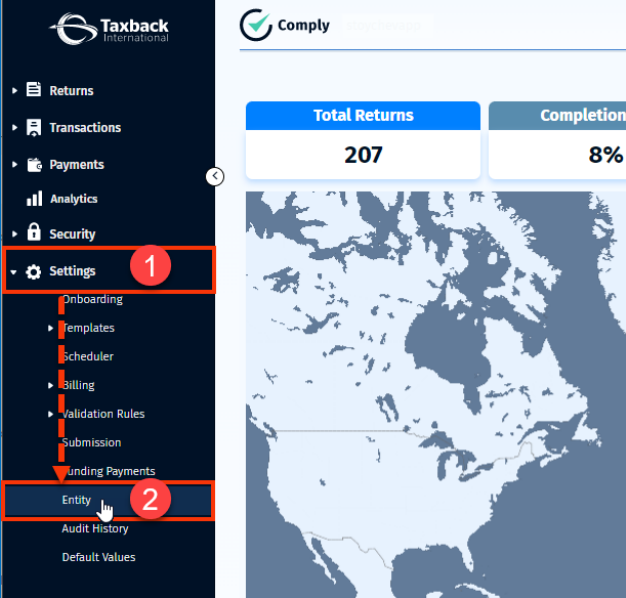
3. Configuration (In Comply)

If a Tax Consultant is filing on behalf of a client, then no action is required here.

If a client is filing on their own behalf, or if a Foreign Tax Consultant is filing on their behalf, then some configuration steps are required.

3.1. Select Submitter Information

The XML files generated for each Submitter Type vary in type and consist of different data. Selecting the Submitter Type here ensures the correct XML template which will be generated.



The screenshot shows the Taxback International Comply interface. On the left is a dark sidebar with a menu. The 'Settings' option is highlighted with a red box and a red circle containing the number '1'. Below 'Settings', the 'Entity' option is also highlighted with a red box and a red circle containing the number '2'. The main content area shows a dashboard with 'Total Returns' (207) and 'Completion' (8%) metrics, and a world map. To the right of the screenshot, on a blue background, are two numbered steps: '1. Go to **Settings**.' and '2. Open the **Entity** sub-menu.'

1. Go to **Settings**.
2. Open the **Entity** sub-menu.

This opens the **Entity Details** page.

1. In the Entity section, select the relevant **Entity**.
2. Click the **Jurisdiction** in the Jurisdiction Country Details section.
3. Click **Visit This Page**.

Group Name
DE-2-22

Entity Details

Entity

Entity Name	Unique Entity Code	Country	In Scope	Entity Status
AA GERMANY ROHAN	AA GERMANY ROHAN	Germany	Yes	Active
DE-3-33	DE-3-33	Germany	Yes	Active
DE-2-22	DE-2-22	Germany	Yes	Active
DE-1-11	DE-1-11	Germany	Yes	Active

Jurisdiction Country Details

Jurisdiction Country: **Germany** VAT Number: **DE1224543**

VAT Deregister **VISIT THIS PAGE**

Funding Bank Details

Here in the Jurisdiction Details page, you can set the Filer Type.

Group Name
DE-2-22 > Germany

Jurisdiction Details

Submitter Information

Filer Type: ☒ Entrepreneur ☐ Filing on your own behalf as an Entrepreneur ☐ Foreign Entrepreneur

View Details

VAT Number:

VAT Registration Type:

Fixed Establishment Address Details

Street Number:

Street Name:

Fiscal Representative Details

Name:

VAT Number:

The options here are:

Filer Type	Description
Entrepreneur	A Tax Consultant filing for you.
Filing on your own behalf	You are filing on your own behalf.
Foreign Entrepreneur	A Foreign Tax Consultant is filing on your behalf.

Please note: By default, this section is set to **Entrepreneur**.

3.2. Changing the Default Submitter Type

If you change the submitter type, you must click Save at the bottom on the screen, at which point you will receive the following notification pop-ups.

3.2.1. File as an Entrepreneur on your own behalf:

The screenshot shows the 'Jurisdiction Details' form. The 'Entrepreneur' option is selected with a checkmark. Below it, the text 'Tick if you are filing on your own behalf as an Entrepreneur' is also checked. A red dashed arrow points from this text to a notification pop-up in the top right corner. The pop-up contains three messages: 'Successfully Updated Entity Jurisdiction Details', 'You have set your filing to file as an Entrepreneur on your own behalf', and 'Provide your certificate and PIN if you are filing electronically'. Below the form, there are sections for 'Fixed Establishment Address Details' and 'Fiscal Representative Details'.

3.2.2. Foreign Entrepreneur:

The screenshot shows the 'Jurisdiction Details' form. The 'Foreign Entrepreneur' option is selected with a checkmark. A notification pop-up in the top right corner contains three messages: 'Successfully Updated Entity Jurisdiction Details', 'Setting has been updated - you are filing as a Foreign Entrepreneur with a Fiscal Representative', and 'Complete your Fiscal Representative Details in Entity Jurisdiction Details'. Below the form, there are sections for 'Fixed Establishment Address Details' and 'Fiscal Representative Details'. The 'Fixed Establishment Address Details' section includes fields for 'Street Number' and 'Street Name'. The 'Fiscal Representative Details' section includes fields for 'Name' and 'VAT Number'.

Please note: If you select the **Foreign Entrepreneur** option, then you are required to complete the **Fiscal Representative Details** section on screen.

☒ Foreign Entrepreneur

Fiscal Representative Details

Name

VAT Number

Street Number

Street Name

Line 2

Zip / Postal Code

City

State / Province / County

Country

3.3. Add PFX Certificate and PIN

What if no PFX Certificate/PIN has been added to your Entity?

In the case where neither a PFX Certificate and/or PIN have been added to your entity, then the following will be displayed on the return.

The screenshot displays the 'Return 145' interface. At the top, a table lists return details: Jurisdiction (Germany), Entity (DE-2-22), Type (VAT Return), Frequency (Monthly), Period (Aug 2024), Status (Data Due), and Filing Deadline (2024-09-10). Below this, a notification box with a red border and an orange warning icon contains the text: 'A Certificate file and a PIN is required to submit the return electronically. Please contact your administrator to add these details for filing electronically.' The interface also features buttons for 'Files', 'Data Validation', 'Transactions', 'Return Validation', and 'Return Review'. At the bottom, there are tabs for 'Data Files' and 'Output Files', and an 'UPLOAD ADDITIONAL FILES' section with a cloud upload icon.

Please note: This Notification appears on all Statuses and for all user roles (Preparer/Reviewer/Approver).

In this scenario, the user has two options:

- Option 1: Open a JIRA Request
- Option 2: Submit It Manually

3.3.1. Open a JIRA Ticket

1. Open a JIRA ticket requesting an email link which can be shared with the client by onboarding to securely send their PFX Certificate and PIN. Below is a sample ticket.

Create issue

Required fields are marked with an asterisk *

Import issues

...

Project *

TBI Operations (TBIOPS)

Issue type *

☒ Task

[Learn about issue types](#)

Status ⓘ

Backlog

This is the issue's initial status upon creation

Summary *

Add Germany Certificate and PIN for [insert Entity Name and CRM ID]

Components

None

Attachment

Drop files to attach or [browse](#)

Description

Normal text

B *I* ... @ <> ⓘ +

Please provide an email link which can be provided to the below client so they can send send the PFX Certificate and PIN/Password to TBI to be added to the undernoted account.

CRM ID:

Entity Name:

☐ Create another issue

Cancel

Create

2. The onboarding team will forward the link to the client.
3. The client should use the link to send their PFX Certificate and PIN to TBI which in turn is added to relevant client account.
4. Once completed, the user can log back into Comply and Resubmit the return.

3.3.2. Submit it Manually

If it is time sensitive, the user can elect to Process the Return and **Submit it Manually**.

1. Go to Return Review.
2. Download the XML file.
3. Log Into the Tax Authority Portal.
4. Upload the File.

4. Submitting

Once the return status in Comply is as "To Submit":

1. Click **Submit**.

The screenshot shows the 'Return 210' interface. At the top, there's a header with fields: Jurisdiction (Germany), Entity (DE-2-22), Type (VAT Return), Frequency (Monthly), Period (Jun 2023), Status (To Submit), and Filing Deadline (2023-07-10). Below this, a bar indicates 'Next action due by 2023-07-10' and links for 'Return Timeline', 'Audit History', and 'Comments'. A row of buttons includes 'Files', 'Data Validation' (with a green checkmark), 'Transactions', 'Return Validation', and 'Return Review'. Below these are tabs for 'Return Boxes' and 'Submission Results'. The 'Return Boxes' tab is active, showing a table with columns: Section, Description, Original Value, Submitted Value, Previous Period, Deviations, Previous Year, and Attachments. The table lists several boxes (Box 81 Net, Box 81 Vat, Box 86 Net, Box 86 Vat, Box 87, Box 35) with their respective descriptions and values. At the bottom, there are three buttons: 'RETURN TO PREPARE', 'CREATE RETURN BOXES', and 'VIEW RETURN'. A red dashed arrow points from the 'To Submit' status field to the 'SUBMIT' button, which is highlighted with a red box.

Section	Description	Original Value	Submitted Value	Previous Period	Deviations	Previous Year	Attachments
Box 81 Net	Vat rate 19% (Taxable Amount Without VAT)						
Box 81 Vat	Vat rate 19% (Tax)						
Box 86 Net	Vat rate 7% (Taxable Amount Without VAT)						
Box 86 Vat	Vat rate 7% (Tax)						
Box 87	Vat rate of 0%						
Box 35	other Vat rates (Taxable Amount Without VAT)						

The return data is exchanged with ERiC via the API and goes through 2 Validation Steps:

- Authentication Process
- Data Validation

Please note: These are both Tax Authority processes.

4.1. Tax Authority Authentication

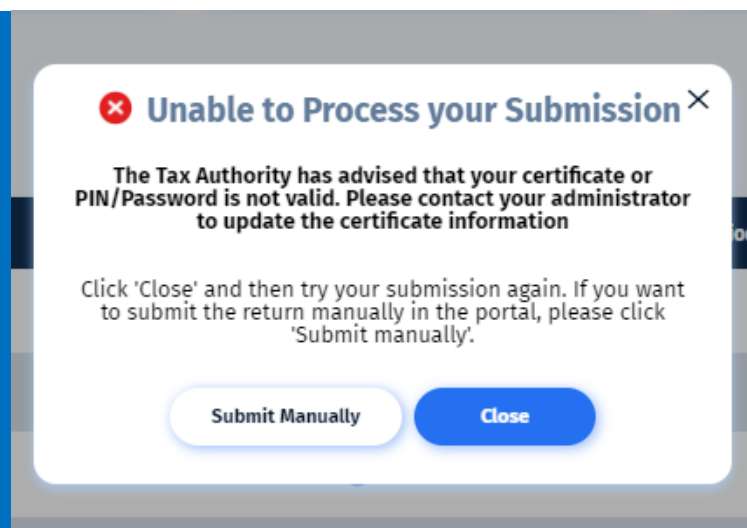
The Authentication process of your PFX Certificate and Password combination is completed by the German Tax Authorities upon clicking the Submit button in Comply.

4.1.1. Authorisation Failed

If an Invalid Certificate or PIN/Password were uploaded.

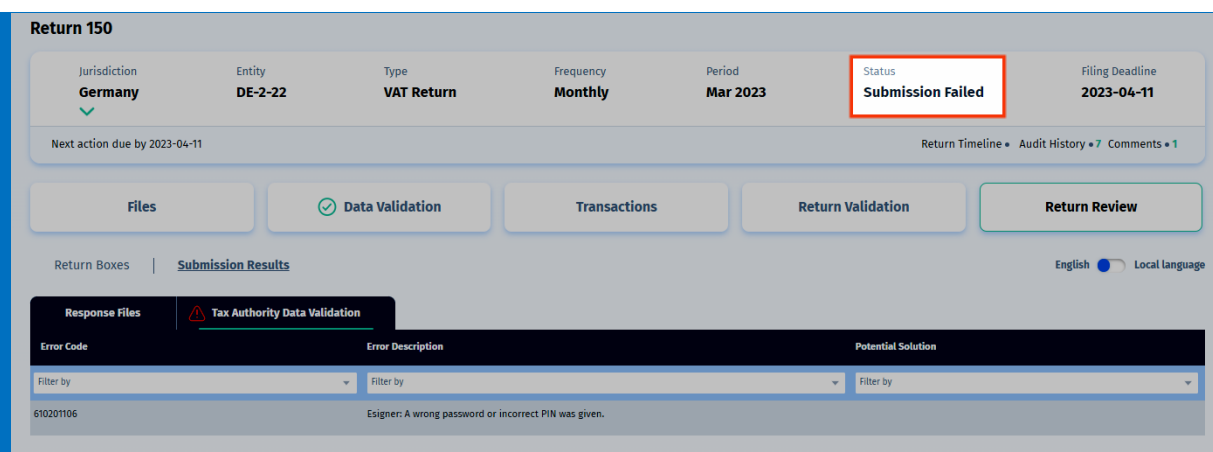
This triggers the following five things **which happen simultaneously**:

- **Error Pop-up**



- **Submission Status**

The Submission Status is changed to **Submission Failed**.



- **Submission Results**

The Submission Results tab is updated. In this example, the Tax Authority Data Validation tab displays an error icon, and the error is displayed below.

Return 150

Jurisdiction	Entity	Type	Frequency	Period	Status	Filing Deadline
Germany	DE-2-22	VAT Return	Monthly	Mar 2023	Submission Failed	2023-04-11

Next action due by 2023-04-11

Return Timeline • Audit History • 7 Comments • 1

Files Data Validation Transactions Return Validation Return Review

Return Boxes | **Submission Results** English Local language

Response Files Tax Authority Data Validation

Error Code	Error Description	Potential Solution
610201106	Esigner: A wrong password or incorrect PIN was given.	

- **Email Notification**

Any errors found during validation of the submission trigger an automatic email to the Preparer/Reviewer/Submitter.

Focused Other By Date ↑

! 📎 📧 Subject Received Size Categories Mention

▼ Today

Taxback ... Action Required: Certificate needs to be updated i... Fri 22/09/2... 80 KB
DE-2-22 / Germany Dear Submitter, Your certificate and PIN/Password in Comply is invalid. In order to submit your request electronically at Germany Tax Authority please log back into Com

Action Required: Certificate needs to be updated in Comply

Taxback International Support <do_not_reply@t...>
To: Keith O'Sullivan

Reply Reply All Forward

Fri 22/09/2023 13:44

This sender is trusted.

DE-2-22 / Germany

Dear Submitter,

Your certificate and PIN/Password in Comply is invalid. In order to submit your request electronically at Germany Tax Authority update this information and retry the submission.

Regards,
TBI Compliance team
[Support at Taxback International](#)

DISCLAIMER
Any delays in the provision of data or approval of summaries may result in penalties from the Tax Authorities. We cannot guarantee timely processing where late.
Any returns, summaries or reports prepared by Taxback International are based on the information provided to us. Any assumptions or adjustments made or in this e-mail or set out in our working papers. Whilst we may perform a review of the data and highlight potential issues, we do not accept any responsibility provided.

- **Audit History**

The Audit History is automatically updated with a Submission failed log.

The screenshot displays the 'Return 150' page in the Comply application. At the top, a navigation bar shows 'Comply stoychevapp' and a user profile 'KO'. Below this, a summary bar for 'Return 150' includes fields for Jurisdiction (Germany), Entity (DE-2-22), Type (VAT Return), Frequency (Monthly), Period (Mar 2023), Status (Submission Failed), and Filing Deadline (2023-04-11). A message states 'Next action due by 2023-04-11'. A tabbed interface shows 'Return Timeline', 'Audit History' (selected and highlighted with a red box), and 'Comments' (1). Below the tabs, there are buttons for 'All Logs', 'Return Logs', and 'Transaction Logs', along with a 'Date range' selector. The main section is titled 'AUDIT HISTORY' and contains a table with columns: All, Date, Event Group, Event Change From, Event Change To, User, Comment, and Type. The table lists several status change events, with the first two rows highlighted by a red box. The first row shows a status change from 'Submitting' to 'Submission Failed' on 22/09/2023 at 13:44:06, with a comment in German. The second row shows a status change from 'Submission Failed' to 'Submitting' on 22/09/2023 at 13:44:02.

All	Date	Event Group	Event Change From	Event Change To	User	Comment	Type
	22/09/2023 13:44:06	Return Status Change	status - Submitting	status - Submission Failed	Keith O'Sullivan	610201106 - eSigner: Es wurde ein falsches Passwort bzw. eine falsche PIN angegeben	Return
	22/09/2023 13:44:02	Return Status Change	status - Submission Failed	status - Submitting	Keith O'Sullivan		Return
	22/09/2023 12:53:42	Return Status Change	status - Submitting	status - Submission Failed	Keith O'Sullivan	610201106 - eSigner: Es wurde ein falsches Passwort bzw. eine falsche PIN angegeben	Return
	22/09/2023 12:53:42	Return Status Change	status - To Submit	status - Submitting	Keith O'Sullivan		Return
	22/09/2023 12:51:44	Return Status Change	status - To Approve	status - To Submit	Keith O'Sullivan		Return
	22/09/2023 12:51:40	Return Status Change	status - To Review	status - To Approve	Keith O'Sullivan		Return

4.1.2. Solutions

In this example, the user has two options:

- **Update Certificate/Password**

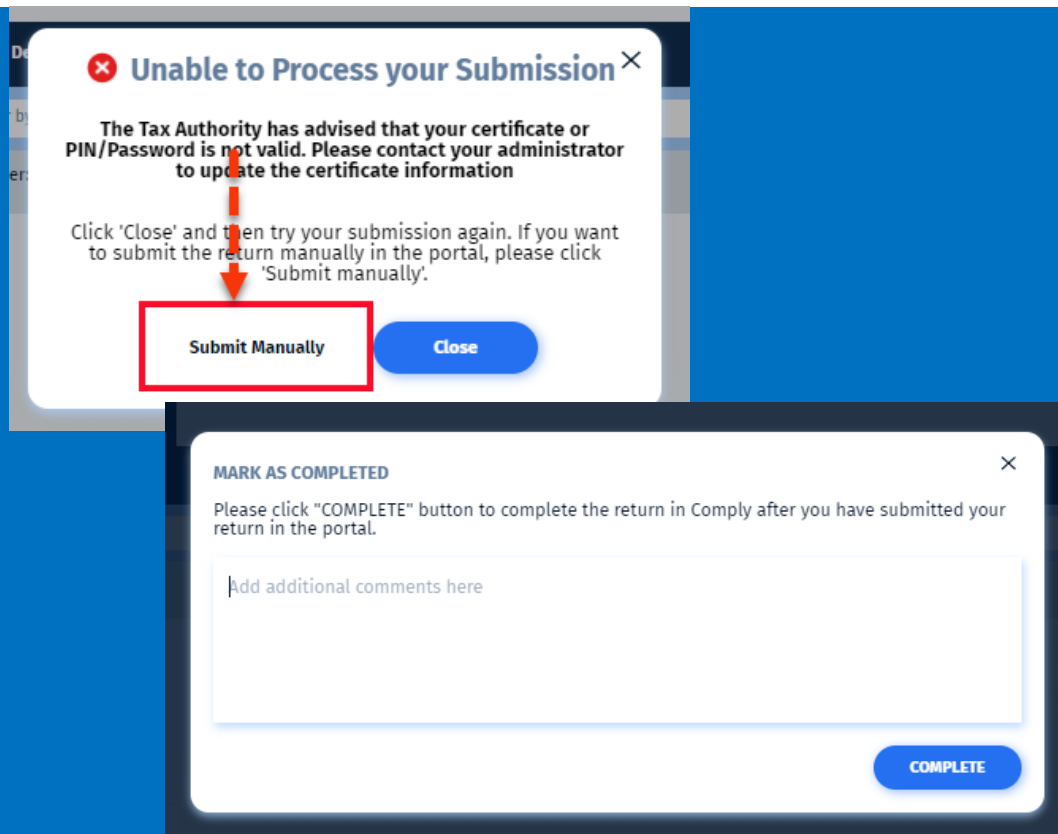
1. Open a JIRA ticket requesting the Relevant PFX Certificate and Password be added.
2. The following are required on the ticket:
 - CRM ID of Client
 - Client name
3. The client will be provided a link to an encrypted email to provide TBI with the PFX Certificate and PIN/Password.
4. These details are then added to the Client account.

When ticket is completed then the return can be re-submitted.

- **Submit Manually**

This option allows the user to skip the API transmission and submit the return manually.

1. Click **Submit Manually**.
2. Go to Return Review.
3. Download the XML file.
4. Log Into the Tax Authority Portal.
5. Upload the File.
6. Click Complete.



4.2. Tax Authority Data Validation

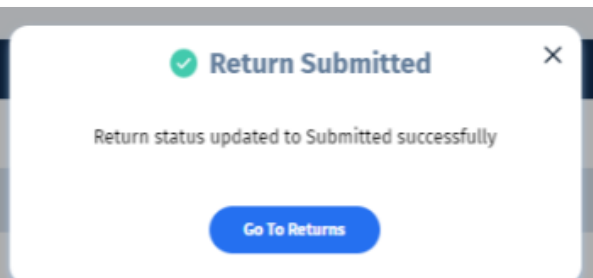
The Tax Authority then validates the return against their own Data requirements. Depending on the result of this validation, the submission will be either:

- Confirmed as Successful
- Failed with an Error

In the case of a failed submission, an error will be displayed in **Tax Authority Data Validation** tab in **Submission Results** on Return Review.

4.2.1. Submitting Successfully

The following pop-up message is displayed when the return is filed successfully.



At this stage, the status on the return changes to “**Submitted.**” The **Go To Returns** button will direct the user back to the All Returns screen.

Submission Files Tab

Once a return has been successfully submitted, a PDF confirmation of the filed return will be populated in the Response Files Tab.

1. Click Submission Results.



2. Click Response Files.
3. Click the PDF Icon – This will include a label E.g., Filed VAT Return/Filed VIES Return etc.
4. Click the PDF (this will download the file)

Please note: The XML file here IS NOT a response file. This is the XML file TBI generated and shared with the TA via the API.

Response File PDF v View Return PDF

The Response File PDF differs from the PDF stored in the VIEW RETURN section of Comply.

Location	Description
Response File	This is the successfully submitted PDF as produced by the Tax Authority
View Return Tab	This is the PDF produced by Comply, which is submitted to the Tax Authority (Before validation).

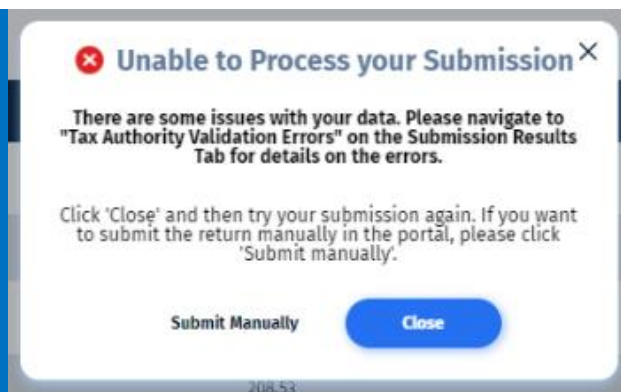
4.2.2. Failed Submission

There may be many reasons why the return fails the validation process, but in all cases, an error will be displayed on Comply explaining and providing basic instruction.

Several things will happen simultaneously:

- **Error Message**

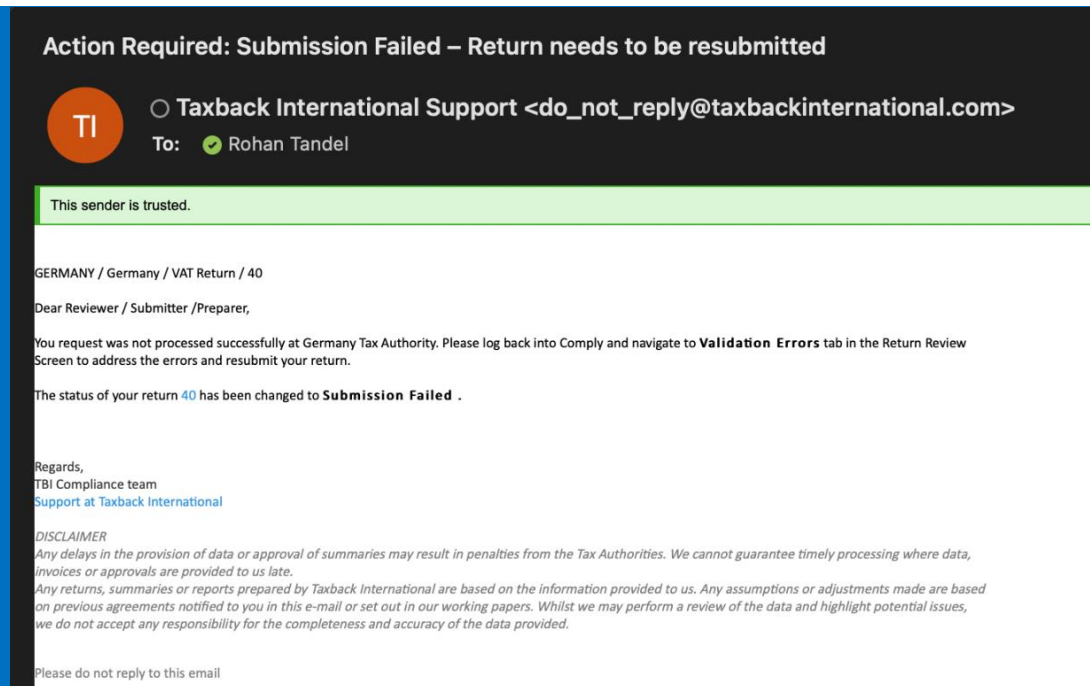
The following generic error will be displayed.



This message identifies that there are some issues with the data submitted which have failed the Tax Authorities Data Validation.

- Email

The following Email is sent to the Preparer/Reviewer/Submitter.

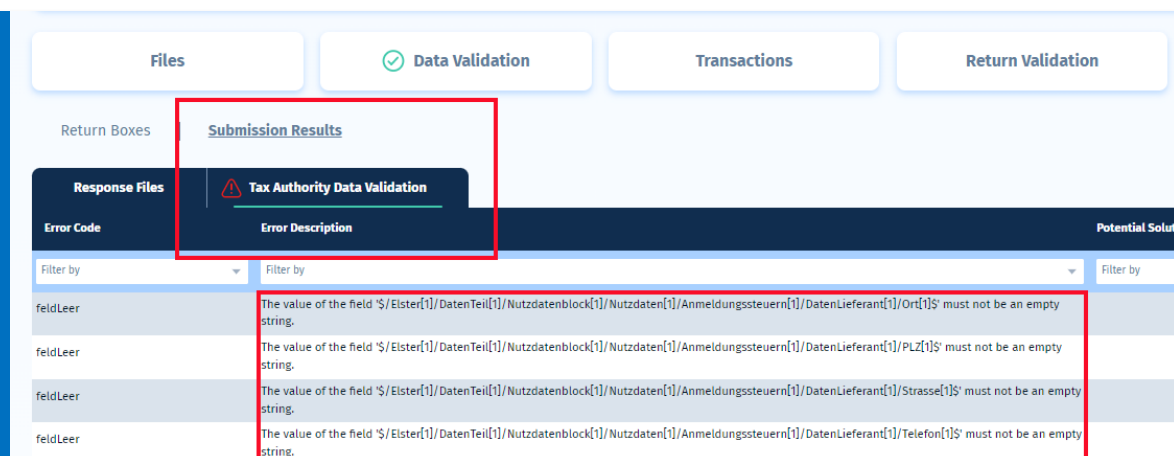


- **Submission Results**

A Validation result will be populated in Submission Results tab on the Return Review screen.

The Tax Authority Data Validation tab will display a red warning tag, and a new row will be added below outlining:

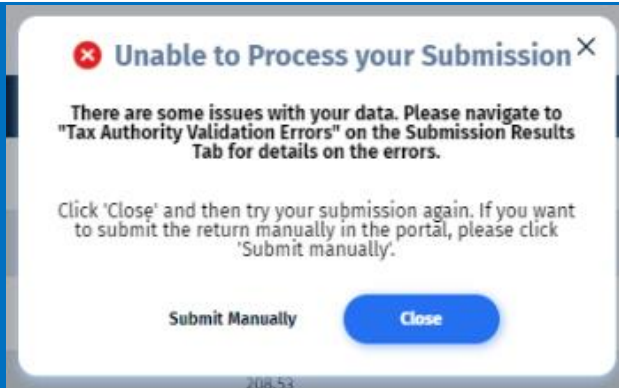
- Error Code
- Error Description



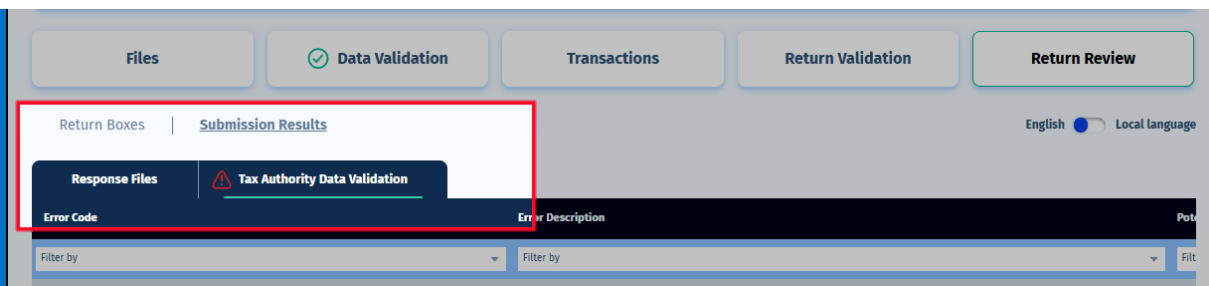
Solutions/Next Steps

There are two available next steps:

- Review the Data
1. Click **Close**. (the status remains on Submission Failed)



2. Click the Submission Results tab on Return Review.
3. Review the Error Description and Potential Solution.



4. Amend the data as required.
5. Resubmit (The Submit button is enabled on the Submission Failed screen.)

- Alternatively, Submit Manually submit to the Tax Office via the Portal.

1. Click **Submit It Manually**.
2. Go to Return Review.
3. Download the XML return file.
4. Login to the Tax Authority Portal.
5. Upload the XML file.

4.3. Return to “To Prepare”

If required, The Return to “To Prepare” button is displayed on the following Statuses:

- To Submit
- Submission Failed

Example: Submission Failed

The screenshot displays the 'Return 209' interface for Germany. At the top, a header bar shows the return details: Jurisdiction (Germany), Entity (DE-2-22), Type (VAT Return), Frequency (Monthly), Period (May 2023), Status (Submission Failed), and Filing Deadline (2023-06-12). Below this, a navigation bar includes buttons for Files, Data Validation, Transactions, Return Validation, and Return Review. A table of 'Return Boxes' is shown, with columns for Section, Description, Original Value, Submitted Value, Previous Period, Deviations, Previous Year, and Attachments. The table lists several boxes (Box 81 Net, Box 81 Vat, Box 86 Net, Box 86 Vat, Box 87, Box 35) with their respective values. At the bottom left, a button labeled 'RETURN TO PREPARE' is highlighted with a red box. A red dashed arrow points from the 'Submission Failed' status to this button. Other buttons at the bottom include 'CREATE RETURN BOXES', 'VIEW RETURN', and 'SUBMIT'.

This will allow the user to bring the status back to “To Prepare” and make any relevant changes.

The user can then make the relevant changes, and process the return through the relevant return flow (To Prepare – To Review – To Approve – To Submit).

Return reverted to To Prepare successfully.

Frequency
Monthly

Period
May 2023

Status
To Prepare

Filing Deadline
2023-06-12

Return Timeline • Audit History • 7 Comments • 1

Transactions

Return Validation

Return Review

English ☒ Local language ☐

	Previous Period ⓘ	Deviations ⓘ	Previous Year ⓘ	Attachments
	0		0	
	0		0	
	0		0	
	0		0	
	0		0	
	0		0	

CREATE RETURN BOXES

VIEW RETURN

SEND FOR REVIEW

Once complete, the user can then Re-Submit the return.

5. Audit History

Once the user clicks Submit on a Return, Comply keeps an Audit History of each step in the process.

The screenshot displays the 'Audit History' section for a VAT Return submission. The top navigation bar shows the submission details: Jurisdiction (Germany), Entity (DE-2-22), Type (VAT Return), Frequency (Monthly), Period (Mar 2023), Status (Submission Failed), and Filing Deadline (2023-04-11). The 'Audit History' link is highlighted in the top navigation bar, and a red dashed arrow points to the 'Event Change' column header in the audit history table.

Date	Event Group	Event Change From	Event Change To	User	Comment
22/09/2023 13:44:06	Return Status Change	status - Submitting	status - Submission Failed	Keith O'Sullivan	610201106 - eSigner: Es wurde ein falsches Pa
22/09/2023 13:44:02	Return Status Change	status - Submission Failed	status - Submitting	Keith O'Sullivan	
22/09/2023 12:53:42	Return Status Change	status - Submitting	status - Submission Failed	Keith O'Sullivan	610201106 - eSigner: Es wurde ein falsches Pa
22/09/2023 12:53:42	Return Status Change	status - To Submit	status - Submitting	Keith O'Sullivan	
22/09/2023 12:51:44	Return Status Change	status - To Approve	status - To Submit	Keith O'Sullivan	
22/09/2023 12:51:40	Return Status Change	status - To Review	status - To Approve	Keith O'Sullivan	
22/09/2023 12:51:36	Return Status Change	status - To Prepare	status - To Review	Keith O'Sullivan	
22/09/2023 12:50:52	Return Status Change	status - Submission Failed	status - To Prepare	Keith O'Sullivan	
22/09/2023 12:49:34	Return Status Change	status - Submitting	status - Submission Failed	Keith O'Sullivan	610201106 - eSigner: Es wurde ein falsches Pa

E.g., Each step is logged here automatically, including:

- The Date and Timestamp
- The change/process recorded.
- The username
- The comment/description – this may include the error in case of a failed submission.